Hidden Treasure

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/41482524.

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Explicit

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Randor (He-Man), Marlena (He-Man)

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Alternate Universe - Pirate, Pirate Catra, Princess Adora (She-Ra), Kidnapping, Princess kidnapping, Mutual Pining, Self-Indulgent, This is 72 Pirate Tropes in a Trench Coat, IDK How I Still Am Missing Pirate Tropes I Tried So Hard To Catch Them All, Bittersweet Ending, kidnapped to lovers, Fluff and Angst, Fluff and Smut, Aftercare, Vaginal Fingering, Sunsets, Bathtubs, Swordfighting, Reading Aloud, Reading, Tenderness, Tender Sex

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by ResFlower

Summary

"My father will hear of this, and he won't rest until I've been returned at once." She goes for outraged, but there's a layer of panic in her voice.

"Oh, I don't doubt that King Randor will be interested in the return of his lovely daughter. Adora is it?" She tests the name on her tongue, liking the way it feels on her lips.

The other woman glares at Catra. "Princess Adora." She corrects haughtily.

Catra rolls her eyes. "Y es, I haven't forgotten that part. A bit instrumental to the purpose of the kidnapping don't you think?"

OR

Pirate Catra kidnaps Princess Adora. Many pirate tropes ensue.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

"I'm going to see about the princess in the brig."She calls to Lonnie as she makes her way to the belly of the ship. She trusted her first mate with her life and knows she can be left in charge while she dealt with the more sensitive issue of their wayward guest.

The woman is stunning, perfect face and cold blue eyes. She's dressed in fine garbs, but they were soiled with muck, her cheek stained with dirt.

"Oh, what a pretty princess."Catra can tell the woman is startled when she looks up, likely not expecting her to walk into her room.

Her hands are rubbed raw, she was clearly trying to escape her shackles. How amusing.

Her eyes were the blue of the clearest sea when the waves were calm and there wasn't land for miles. It distracts Catra for a moment from the blush on her face.

She smirks, noticing the way the princess stares at her mouth slightly open. "Something the matter?"She then looks at the grungy cell. "I guess aside from the kidnapping."She says dismissively .

"My father will hear of this, and he won't rest until I've been returned at once."She goes for outraged, but there's a layer of panic in her voice.

"Oh, I don't doubt that King Randor will be interested in the return of his lovely daughter. Adora is it?"She tests the name on her tongue, liking the way it feels on her lips.

The other woman glares at Catra. "Princess Adora."She corrects haughtily.

Catra rolls her eyes. "Y es, I haven't forgotten that part. A bit instrumental to the purpose of the kidnapping don't you think?"She gets closer to the bars of the cell.

"Look, your stay doesn't have to be unpleasant," Catra explains, hoping the princess won't be stubborn enough to make this more difficult than necessary. "I'll have a warm bed with your name on it if you just cooperate."

She makes a disgruntled noise. "The captain's I take it." She makes a face as of she'd rather drown.

"Your own bed, with someone standing watch to make sure you don't do anything stupid."

Catra's typically in the business of freeing slaves and trafficking cargo, not kidnapping. But she couldn't resist the opportunity for such a high payoff as the return of a princess would surely bring.

"I don't trust any pig of a man that would kidnap an innocent. Tell your captain that I very disrespectfully refuse any negotiations with him and if he wishes he could negotiate with me to my face." She spits out anger rolling over her every expression.

Catra tenses eyeing the princess critically. "First of all, I doubt an innocent Princess Adora." She makes a show of eyeing her to cover up her real annoyance at the princess's naivety. "And second, the captain of the ship is no man. You do have a way with assumptions, don't you?"

Princess Adora looks flustered for a moment before she shoots Catra a determined look. "Regardless of gender, I stand by what I said."

"Well, I'm right here princess. What do you have to tell me?" She raises her arms, waistcoat opening some with the movement.

The princess gapes. "You're the captain?"

"That's what I just said," Catra says with a huff of annoyance. "Why, do I not look like a captain?" She goads now pressing herself up to the bars.

Her whole life she's been told she isn't good enough, that the sea is no place for a woman. She built this life for herself with blood and righteous anger and she'd be damned if a princess looks down her nose at it.

"No, you're just so..." The woman trails off, the shackles clanging as she takes a step forward eyes on Catra.

"What?" She demands, outright angry.

"Pretty." Catra looks at the princess with wide eyes not expecting that at all. She realizes her admission a moment later and rushes on. "Pretty young! I mean you're quite young to be a captain, aren't you? You can't be much older than I am." She laughs nervously as if she made a faux pas at a dinner party, not unwittingly calling her captor attractive.

Catra smirks, enjoying Adora's embarrassment. The thought that the princess, even for a moment, thought she was *pretty* of all things warmed her to her bones.

"Well, no one could blame you for finding me pleasing to look at." She makes a show of fiddling with the edge of her peasant shirt, noting how Adora's eyes drop down to her collar bones. The princess is beet red.

She drops a bit of her swagger and grabs one of the shackles the princess is in, careful not to touch her. "This can't be comfortable Princess. I'm nothing if not a gentleman. If you promise to not be a problem, I don't see why you have to be treated this way." Her eyes wander the brig. "Think about it, Princess Adora."

"You're a pirate. A scoundrel." She says as she glares at Catra.

Catra smirks. "Don't you know princess? Sometimes scoundrels make the best gentlemen."

She leaves the princess with those parting words. When she closes the door of the brig, she leans against the door, a stupid smile on her face, her heart thundering in her chest. She can already tell the princess is nothing but trouble.

It takes three days for the Princess to break and request an audience with the captain. It took her longer than Catra expected, and she'd grown to grudgingly respect her because of it. She'd avoided the brig since that first day, sending Lonnie in her stead to give Adora her meals and take her out to walk about the deck twice a day.

Catra made sure she was on deck so she could see the captive. She looked well fed and well treated, which is all that really mattered. Catra didn't stare at her frame or wonder where Lonnie was finding more clean dresses for her, and she certainly didn't glance away like a schoolgirl whenever Adora caught her stare.

She goes down to the brig. As she'd ordered it was substantially cleaner and the shackles around Adora's wrists were gone.

"Hello Princess Adora." She stated, before crossing her arms. The blonde followed the movement looking Catra up and down. She bit her lip to keep from smirking. She's wearing her leather boots, but she left her waistcoat behind, instead in a deep burgundy peasant shirt.

"I wanted to speak with you." She points out the obvious.

Catra raises an eyebrow waiting for her to get on with it. "Right- well you said that the ship had better accommodations. If I cooperated?" She prompts.

Catra lets her struggle for a moment more before stepping in. "Yes. If you promise to not slit my crew's throat and not jump overboard you can have a room with an actual bed and a bit more freedom about the ship."

"You're all surprisingly cordial for a band of pirates."She points out through narrowed eyes.

"Because you have so much experience with pirates?"Catra asks sharply. "I bet I've met more princesses than you have pirates."

It's a lie but one that makes the princess' eyes light with rage. "You just kidnap any princess?This is just a typical Tuesday for you."She blusters.

"Absolutely ."She grins. "Now , you promise to behave?"

The words make the princess flush. "Fine."She says curtly . "When are we arriving in Eternia?"

"It should take about a month give or take a few days. We already sent an emissary with news of your arrival and the ransom demand." Seahawk was as quick as can be on the sea. The only real trouble is letters are flammable but she's never had him bungle one of her tasks.

"I can't wait to be off this stupid ship."She mutters under her breath.

Catra ignores it, offering her arm after she opens the cell door. The princess ignores that, walking ahead and opening the brig door herself. Catra walks behind her, enjoying the sway of her hips as they climb the stairs.

"This is your room princess."She gestures toward the captain's bed.

After a day of showing the princess around it's finally time to sleep. Adora stiffens for a moment looking between the bed and Catra but says nothing. She demurely hides behind the curtain on the far side of the room where the bathtub is and changes into a pair of night clothes Lonnie had provided her. She looks so different outside of the dresses she usually wore.

"Goodnight Princess." She calls as she turns to get her own sleeping quarter in order .

"What are you doing?" Adora sits up with a confused purse of her lip.

Catra raises her eyebrow in response. "Going to my bed." She points at the hammock she set up earlier near the door.

Her pretty pink lips pop into an "oh" of surprise. Between her expression and how much space she left on the far side of the bed Catra realizes where her head is.

She smirks walking towards the bed. "Did you think we were going to be cuddling tonight, princess?"

She sputters, turning redder by the minute. "I—what else was I supposed to think! This is your bed, isn't it?"

"What happen to the captain being a pig and you'd never lay next to him." She jeers, enjoying the way the princess looked away in embarrassment. She feels a twinge of guilt and backs off, walking back towards her hammock. "Don't worry princess. I told you, I'm a gentleman. I'll be right here."

Adora is rolling and turning in the bed back and forth and she fixes Catra and her hammock with a glare. "You're such an ass."

"Clearly you like this ass. How embarrassing for you." She closes her eyes and delights in Adora's indignant yelp. "Good night princess, I do need beauty rest to stay this gorgeous you know."

Adora doesn't respond but Catra has to hold back her laugh as she hears the covers thrash, the princess clearly turning to face away from the hammock.

"I'm going to die of boredom before you manage to get your ransom, Captain." She says sounds bored enough that her statement might

be true.

"I'm sorry this pleasure cruise isn't up to her highness' standards." She eyes the woman for a moment. "W ould you like a book?" She offers suddenly. She hadn't thought of it before, but she wouldn't mind sparing a book from her collection for the princess.

"Y ou have books?" She asks curiously .

Catra rolls her eyes. "No, I of fered you something I don't have to mess with you."

"Y ou could." She says crossly , a blush rising to her cheeks.

Catra digs under her bed where she has her pleasure reading until she finds a suitable one.

"Here." The fact that she pulls out her favorite book is of no consequence and is unintentional. Still, when she hands it to Adora it feels like handing a piece of herself.

She looks at the book, carefully a finger tracing over the spine. She stops when she flips the front cover open. "Is this your name Captain?" She looks up at Catra. "Caterina?"

Catra laughs. "That hasn't been my name in a long time, princess." She gives a short bow. "My name is Catra. V ery rude of me not to introduce myself to royalty."

Adora smiles a bit unsurely. She looks back down at the book. "This is a favorite of my mother's." She shares.

"Then your mother has excellent taste. It ' s my favorite." Catra pulls another book out from under her bed and goes to lie in her hammock. "Let me know when you'd like the lights out." She says casually as she opens her own book.

"Y ou're sleeping there again?" She asks with a furrowed brow .

"Y es. Keeping guard of a stubborn princess."She reminds lightly .

Adora's face sours at that. "What would I do jump in the ocean? I dont need a guard."She huf fs.

"I dont put it past you."She says, eyes never leaving her book.

Adora scoffs. "I'll have you know Im an excellent swimmer , but Im not arrogant enough to think I can swim across the ocean."

"And I hate the water ,"Catra says idly with a page turn. "I'd just let you drown."

"Really ."Adora raises a brow . "A pirate that hates water?"

"Y es. If you're a successful pirate you're rarely *in* the water. Now, let me read my book in peace."

"A y Captain."Adora rolls her eyes, settling into Catra' s bed and reading quietly sans the occasional page flip.

"Captain."She says the title formally . They are standing on the deck of the ship as Catra navigates, capitalizing on a wind current that is likely to speed their progress.

"Y es, Princess Adora."She says absentmindedly .

"I'd like a dif ferent set of clothes."She informs her tugging lightly on the skirt of her dress.

Catra side eyes the blonde. "Oh, yes, let me bring the seamstress in for you."She makes a show of looking around and making a surprised face when there are in fact no seamstresses on the ship.

Adora releases a heavy sigh. "Y ou're insuf ferable."

"W ell your highness, Im in the middle of the ocean. W e have a limited set of dresses for you."She feels like pointing out that this

seems like a mild complaint considering she isnt on the ship of her free will but refrains.

She shakes her head. "I dont want a dress."

Catra looks at the princess, furrowing her brow. "Oh. Okay . What do you want?"

"Pants. Shirt. Maybe a belt?" She bites her lip and shifts uncertainly on her toes.

Catra thinks about it. "Alright lets go to captain's quarters I think I have something." She looks at her first mate. "Lonnie! Get someone to man the ship while I attend to the princess."

She ignores Lonnie's smirk and shoves her shoulder into her as a silent admonishing when she passes by. She leads the princess below deck and into their shared room.

Catra goes into her armoire and pulls out a few of each, older clothes that used to belong to Scorpia. "These probably need to be taken in, but itll be easier than wearing anything I fit into." She hands them over to the princess whose eyes widen in surprise.

"Thank you. Can I ask whose clothes are these?" She says with a furrowed brow as she looks at the larger clothes.

"An old friend who found she wasnt suited for a pirate's life. Married a florist and lives in a village with three brats of their own." She says with a fond smile. She's happy that her former first mate found what truly fulfilled her, but she also missed having her here. She cant imagine having that type of life on land.

"That sounds nice." The princess says under her breath, a faraway look in her eyes. "Do you have a needle and thread?"

She produces a small wooden box. "Do you need to me get someone to fix these for you?" Catra asks.

Adora shakes her head. "No, a good lady knows how to alter her own clothing."The lofty tone she uses feels like she's mocking someone.

"Who forced you to be a lady , Princess?"Catra asks with a teasing grin.

Adora rolls her eyes with a fond smile. "My mother obviously ."

For a moment the silence is warm and comfortable, then she looks up and her eyes catch Adora's, and she remembers that this is her captive, not a friend.

"If you dont need anything else, I need to go above deck."She says stiffly. Adora nods, sitting down and opening the box as she sets to work on the shirts. Catra doesnt look back, once again leaning against the door after she exits the room with all her thoughts straining to the woman inside it.

With the appropriate clothes, Adora ends up going everywhere, learning all there is to know about the ship. As Catra navigates and orders different people to different tasks, she never fails to see the inqisitive blonde either helping or studying someone else's movements.

One day, she finds her looking like she's fighting a length of rope. "Princess Adora, are you actively sabotaging the ship?"She asks curiously.

The woman throws down the rope crossing her arms across her chest. "No!Im just trying to tie the stupid knot!It looks so easy when other people do it."

"Look, princess."She calmly and slowly turns the rope until she has a perfect bowline knot, the end of the rope looping perfectly.

"Looking doesn't make me able to do it." She grumbles, glaring at the rope.

Catra sighs. "Grab the rope." She pulls the knot out and hands it to Adora. "Alright. Place a loop here." She points at a place she deems suitable. "Then place the end through the hole you've just created."

The princess does just that, her tongue sticking out of her mouth in concentration. Adora clears her throat, looking at Catra expectantly. That's when she realizes she's staring.

"Ah yes, well now you have to wrap the end around the main length of rope and then make sure to loop it into the original hole." She rushes to explain.

Adora furrows her brow for a moment until Catra points to the place she is discussing, then her face clears. She carefully loops and tugs, a bowline knot on the end of the rope, sure as if Catra had done it herself.

"I did it!" She looks up at Catra, a proud look of excitement shining in her eyes.

She can't help but smile. "Congratulations princess, you can now tie the king of knots."

"Thank you, captain." She turns and undoes the knot to practice again, not noticing how Catras breath catches at the expression of gratitude.

"I can see how some of this stuff has a certain appeal to it," Adora says absentmindedly, this time her fingers nimbly doing the knot and untying it.

"Yes, your majesty?"

"Adora." She corrects without a thought still fiddling with the rope. "When did you become a pirate?"

"Well, that's a long story princess." She hedges, tugging on her waistcoat.

Adora stops for a moment, squaring Catra with a look that would have a lesser woman shaking in her boots. "We have time." She decides in a commanding tone she must use when she's at the palace.

Catra rolls her eyes. "When I was seventeen, I left my kingdom and joined the navy in Salineas. Cut my hair and posed as a man." She runs her fingers through her short curls. "The haircut grew on me, naval discipline? Not as much."

Her time in the navy was interesting if only for the fact that it taught her that she prefers to bed women. She doesn't tell the princess this. "I made a friend, Seahawk, and together we left the military and stole a ship. From then on it was a pirate's life for both of us."

"The Salineans didn't say anything about a stolen ship by two naval officers?"

Catra's lips twitch. "At the time Seahawk was having a tryst with the princess of Salineas. I remain unconvinced that he doesn't visit her occasionally."

Adora gasps aloud. "Mermista?" Catra forgot that while the Salineas princess is almost fictional to her, she might have been someone Adora knew well.

"One and the same." She confirms.

Adora stares pensively, running her hands over the ropes again. "That makes sense. She's a bit of a rebel."

"And you? Are you a rebel?" Catra asks.

Adora shakes her head. "No, not at all." Her eyes focus out on the water. "I love my kingdom with all I am and from a young age, I was

taught that my duty is to it above all else. Ive never done anything that could be considered anything like rebellion."

Catra studies her face, the almost sad quality of it. She cant imagine it, the burden of a nation sitting on one pair of shoulders. "That sounds rather lonely."She murmurs.

Adora winces at the word. "It is."She agrees readily . "She lets out a short hard laugh. "You know it shouldnt be so, but on the ship, Ive felt free."She shakes her head. "Isnt that ridiculous? Im a prisoner and I feel freer here than I do in my palace."

"I dont think thats ridiculous at all."Catra' s whispers, her heart squeezing painfully in her chest for this gorgeous woman. "The sea *is* freedom. Thats why she calls to me. You can go anywhere you want and *be* anything you want out on the water, miles away from those who would judge or hurt you."Its too much to tell a captive but Catra cant stand for Adora to think she' s alone on this.

The princess looks at Catra and smiles she then looks out at the ocean, the sun falling slowly towards the water, making the sky orange. "She is beautiful,"Adora says eyes taking in the view .

"She is."Catra agrees softly , eyes only for Adora. "Have you ever watched the sunset over the water?"

Adora turns to look at her, wispy hairs falling out of her ponytail and gently swaying in the breeze. "No. Not on the water ."She amends.

"Well, the best view of any sunset in the world is right on this deck if you sit up there."She points to a raised portion of the deck. "Want to sit there and watch?"

Adora's mouth quirks into a smile and she nods. They quickly sit a foot apart and watch the sun roll through its procession of color, orange to pink and purple, and finally a dark blue that ends in darkness.

They dont say much, and they never touch but Catra doesnt think shes ever felt more connected to another human being in her life.

"Its a strategy game."Catra laughs at Adoras bewildered look when Catra takes her queen once again. "Use *strategy* next time and maybe youll have a chance."

One of Catra's quiet loves is a good game of chess, something she and Lonnie partake in on long boring nights with nothing to do. Adora is incredibly intelligent but lacks the patience to see the moves that Catra plots. She needs to slow down and really think things through. If she gives it even a second thought, Catra is sure she wouldnt have won as handedly.

A strange look crosses Adoras face. "My father used to say that to me."She looks sad now with her thin smile. "Adora, youre too headstrong like me, why dont you take after your mother and think of a strategy that takes you more than five minutes to put together"? Her chuckle is watery. "I miss them."

That sobers Catra. "If you want to write a letter to them, I can make sure it arrives."She of fers.

"I think thatll make them sadder . And me too honestly. Ill see them soon enough."She eyes Catra for a moment. "T wo weeks still, right"?

"Its just two more weeks."She nods. She reaches her hand over , to hold the princess' hand, forgetting herself for a moment. Just before she does, she catches herself and pulls back. Princesses arent meant to be touched by pirates anyway.

"Why do you target certain ships from the Fright Zone"?She asks. The princess resurfaces after they take down another Fright Zone ship allowing the slaves on it a chance to sail away to freedom.

Catra's face contorts into a sneer. "They're slavers. The Fright Zone is a despicable kingdom, and I would sink every single ship of their navy and not feel an ounce of remorse."

"Slavers still? I thought that practice was long gone."Adora pales, a worried look crossing her face.

Catra shakes her head. "No. They just hide it better than most."

"I had no idea. That's absolutely barbarous."Anger has seeped into Adora's voice and judgment in her eyes.

"It is. That's why we take them for all they have."She sends the princess a cocky smile.

Adora stares at her for a moment and then her eyes light up as if she's been let into a secret. "You're not a hardened pirate captain at all."She says gleefully .

Catra groans, smile dropping momentarily. "That was not the deduction you were meant to make from this situation."

"I don't know what other deduction I could make,"Adora says with an overly innocent face on. Catra doesn't like how familiar the princess is getting with her.

"I'm very much a criminal your majesty and I'm dangerous. You should do well to remember that."She says more seriously .

Adora rolls her eyes. "I'm not an idiot. I've seen you take down three ships in a week. You're clearly capable."Then her voice turns teasing again. "But you do it for good reasons which makes you a softie."

Catra gasps out loud indignantly. It catches Lonnie's attention. "What Catra? She's just caught on to what we all know ."

"I should make you mop the decks for that!"Catra would feel more insulted if her palms weren't sweating at the thought of the princess

thinking she was good.

Catra has to take off her leathers after she beats the third member of her crew, the waistcoat a bit too heavy for all her exertion.

"What are you all doing?" Adora asks as she eyes everyone curiously. She'd spent the majority of the morning reading down below and was now resurfacing.

"Sparring!" One of the crewmates offers excitedly.

It's an important thing, to fight amongst the crew and keep skills sharp and it doubles as just good fun, especially on long stretches at sea like this.

"Can I challenge the captain then?" She asks teasingly but her eyes light with a fire that shows she means it.

Silence overtakes the crew as Catra considers it eyeing the princess. It's dangerous, giving the princess an actual weapon but they are out at sea, and she doesn't take Adora as a fool who would attempt to escape at an inopportune moment.

"Fine Princess. I don't see why not." She finally allows.

A few of the crewmembers hold put their swords. Adora picks the heaviest broad sword lifting it easily into a perfect fighting stance. Catra looks at her with surprise.

"Already scared?" She goads. She hears the crew chuckle at that, and Catra tosses them a glare.

"Never ." She swears although Adora is imposing to look at. They both hold their swords up and start circling each other.

Adora runs at Catra first, using her longer body to her advantage. Catra quickly ducks and Adora almost slams into the side of the ship.

"Strategy princess!" She jeers as she turns to look at her .

Adora is frustrated but her eyes are a live wire, an electric blue that's haunting. She swings again, this time with a more measured approach. Catra meets every swing but that's quickly a losing battle because the princess is surprisingly strong and technically skilled.

Catra swings from the mast and gets behind the princess. She quickly turns and keeps her attack, eyes zeroing in on Catra. She leads the princess to a loose plank, knowing that it'll give her victory. The moment she sees Adora step on it, she pushes down hard, making Adora stumble on the other end.

She shoves her down and the princess tumbles, her sword clattering out of arms reach. Catra smirks as she holds the princess at sword point.

She glares up at Catra. "That's not a fair fight."

"Pirates don't play fair princess." She raises an eyebrow .

Adora's expression clears for a moment and she leans up almost sitting. The fight loosened her shirt, the collar sliding and exposing her shoulder. Between that and her heavy breathing, this is the most outright indecent she's seen the princess and Catra can't help her stare.

Suddenly there's hardwood under her back and the Princess is above her, a victorious grin as she holds Catra's own sword to her throat. Catra has no idea how she managed to tackle her to the ground and take her sword.

For a second the metal is pressing too tightly into her neck and she thinks that this is how she'll die. Fooled into giving a beautiful woman a sword and then gawking at her shoulder. Absolutely pathetic.

But Adora loosens her grip on the sword but still keeps it at Catra's neck as she leans forward. "You might know this ship, Captain, but I

know *you*."She whispers hotly into Catra's ear , an embarrassing shiver running down her spine at the sensation.

Adora grins impishly and then stands, holding her hand out to help Catra stand. She takes the offered hand and the sword from Adora which she offers back with no fuss.

"Y ou could have killed me just now ."Catra points out as the crew disperses.

Adora shrugs. "I could have but that wasn't what I was looking for . Not what I *want*."She gives Catra an intense stare that she doesn't understand before she walks off fixing her shirt as she goes.

That night Catra is absolutely drenched in sweat, sticky and exhausted. She had to beat every other crew member to prove a point after she was smacked to the ground by the princess.

What she needs is to run a bath. It isn't often that she' s allowed such a luxury, usually scrubbing down with cold water to stay clean efficiently. But it has been a good long while and she's exhausted. She asks a crewmate to bring up the heated water to the captain's quarters.

When she gets to her room, she realizes she forgot about Adora. The princess is looking at the bathtub with steaming water with a longing that belongs on the cover of a romance novel.

"Is that for me?"And her voice is so hopeful, eyes shining, Catra has no hope of saying no.

"Y es, I figured that it's been a while since you took a bath."She lies. "Consider it your prize for besting me today ."

Her smile is downright gleeful, and she is barely behind the privacy screen before she's tugging off her clothes, not even bothering to wait for Catra to leave the room. Catra can make out the silhouette

of the princess and immediately looks away, but not before seeing the shape of her breast and her waist as she turns towards the tub.

Catra is about to leave when she hears a long drawn-out moan as Adora enters the water. She grips the doorknob tightly and closes her eyes the wanton sound crashing through her. She's about to make a quick exit when she hears Adora call out. "Captain?"

Catra takes a shuddering breath, her sore muscles in more pain as she clenches and damns everything to hell. She turns around. "Yes, princess?" She hates how breathless her voice sounds, worse than when she was sword fighting today.

"Would you read to me?" Adora's question is soft and honest, making it a little easier to breathe. "I know it's childish, but I love being read to." She confesses shyly and Catra can almost imagine the soft smile on her face and the blush on her cheeks that goes down into the water—

"Yes princess, I'll read to you." She says quickly. She grabs the latest book Adora is devouring, flipping to the marked page as she sits on the chair just this side if the privacy screen.

The next hour is the hardest test of self-control any human being had been asked to endure. Catra keeps her eyes on the book methodically flipping pages and reading aloud. Meanwhile, she could hear every soft sigh, every drip of water, every slide of Adora's hands as she washed her hair and then herself.

When she reaches the end of the book, she hears nothing from the other side of the privacy screen. "Princess Adora?" She calls softly.

She hears a splash of water and then sees her figure as she stands and walks out of the tub, drying herself off. Catra looks away as she bends over to put on her pants, going to the far side of the room putting as much distance as possible between her and the princess.

She steps out from behind the screen, a content, almost lazy smile on her face as she wrings out her long blonde hair, little droplets running down her collarbone and between her breasts. "Thank you so much, captain. That was an immeasurably enjoyable experience."

Before Catra cracks and asks Adora about a number of enjoyable experiences they could have together, she nods. "I'm glad you enjoyed it. Ill be taking my own bath now ." She walks behind the screen feeling Adora's eyes following her .

Catra strips quickly , hissing when she enters the bath. Even now, the lukewarm water feels like heaven, a respite from the sweat and grime she felt all day on her body. She tries her best to go under the water and wet her hair, ignoring that mere moments ago the princess was naked in the same water she was in. Ignoring how badly she'd wanted to join her .

Adora's voice breaks out over the sound if sloshing water . "The bath was always meant for you, wasn't it?" Embarrassment colors her words and Catra hears a slapping sound, no doubt Adora bringing a hand to her face. She almost regrets not seeing the horrified look on the princess's face right now.

"I don't mind sharing princess." She tries to make it sound cocky , but she really can't, not naked and wet, most of her body responding to the nearness of the princess.

For a moment everything is quiet again and she assumes Adora has walked out, likely looking for something to eat. She's surprised when she hears her start speaking—not speaking, reading. She recognizes the first few lines as the book she first gave Adora, her favorite.

She's never had anyone read to her . As a child, she lived on the streets and as a teenager, before the navy, she was nothing to anyone. This type of soft affection was reserved for children who were loved, not Catra. Never Catra. To her surprise, she feels tears

run down her face. She bites her lips to try to keep the sobs in and moves the water to disguise the noise.

Of course, Adora picks up on it anyway stopping her reading. "Captain? Are you alright?" Adora sounds concerned and her voice grows nearer as if she's taken a step towards the tub.

Catra's sniffles become more obvious, and the air becomes tense, Adora clearly confused as to what's happening.

"No one has ever read to me before." Catra finally admits. "It's very nice. Thank you."

"You're welcome." The blonde says unsurely . She pauses. "Would you like me to keep going?"

For a moment Catra is tempted to say yes. To let herself listen to Adora's melodious voice as she soaks and allow herself to be coddled this way. To be soft and vulnerable and open in a way she simply can't be in the life she' s chosen to lead.

"I think I'd prefer to take my bath in silence if that's alright." She bites her lips. "Maybe some other time?" She asks hopefully .

She hears the princess shuffle closer and she thinks she might be touching the screen. "Of course captain. I'll let you collect yourself. I'll be in the gallery finding food if you need me." Her voice is patient and soft and Catra isn't sure what to make of it.

She sits in the tub, cold now, for another fifteen minutes just trying to make her body her own once again. Once she reigns herself in, she dries off and gets ready for bed.

That night, Adora reads aloud to herself occasionally glancing at Catra across the room in her hammock. She falls asleep to the sound of her voice. It's the best night of sleep in her life.

She doesn't notice Adora coming towards the rowdy group of pirates until it's way too late.

"The princess wants to play!" One of them yells and they start whooping and hollering at Adora. She smiles wide, bouncing on her toes.

She eyes Adora, wondering if she's interested in playing. It's a dice game, so really, it's a lying game. She doesn't take the princess for the deceitful sort. Still, she nods when she's offered a cup and dice, watching the crew around her play.

At first, Adora struggles to learn the rules as her cup covers her dice and she guesses what's under the other person's cup. But then she beats Catra three times in a row.

"You're cheating!" She says as the crew laughs some of the patting the princess on the back.

Adora shakes her head, smirking. "You have a tell." She says knowingly.

"No, I don't." Catra immediately denies it. She's been lying to get by her whole life she can't be figured out by some princess whose known her for three weeks.

"What do you want to bet pirate? I'll beat you again." The crew roars at that whooping and calling out suggestions, some fun and others plain lecherous.

Catra raises an eyebrow. "Fine. Next round, if I win you'll owe me a favor. What do you want."

She stares at Catra in a way that makes her feel like Adora's the pirate here. "I'll take a favor as well."

She doesn't know what tell Adora thinks Catra has but she knows the blonde's tell. She's been watching her enough in the last few

weeks. Immediately, she notices that Adora reaches up and crosses one arm over her chest. "I've got five."She says confidently , but her eyes tighten.

"No, you don't. I'm calling it."Adora groans as she turns over her cup and it isn't the five she suggested it would be.

"I want to play against the princess!"A crew mate says loudly and Adora laughs turning to face them.

Catra rolls her eyes. "I won't forget princess. I will collect later ."She warns.

Adora meets her stare for a moment and nods with a laugh before turning her attention to her next match.

By the end of the night, Adora did admirably well until one of the crew members snuck her the rum. Then she lost everything she gained reputationally in addition to the ability to walk in a straight line.

Catra practically has to haul her into the bedroom, the princess a giggling mess. She looks down at the hazy relaxed smile on her face.

She drops her on the bed and that sets off a new wave of laughs. Catra takes a breath to listen to it. She decides the princess should always be happy like this, although maybe with less liquor .

"Captain."She calls out too loud. "Join me."She waves her arm to the side lazily .

"I think we're done for the night."Catra starts to walk away but Adora grips her hand pulling her a hair's breadth away.

"Why? Never been with a woman before?"Her eyes darken as she licks her lips. "I can take care of you."She murmurs lowly eyes practically undressing Catra of her leathers.

This is an assassination attempt pure and simple. Adora is trying to kill her. She backs away already mourning the loss of Adora's hand on hers, her closeness.

Catra took a deep breath through her nose. "Adora. You're drunk." She tries for stern but it's hard when the woman in question is holding her gaze so intensely. "You're going to sleep. I'm going to sleep over there. And I'll see you in the morning."She says it slowly and firmly.

She watches the blonde deflate, cuddling into the bed with a pout. "But what if I want you to besmirch me?"She says crossly. She suddenly gets up and strips down to her underwear then settles back under the covers.

Catra keeps her eyes on the ceiling and prays for some deity to give her patience and self-control. "Your majesty, no besmirching."She never thought she'd ever have to say that sentence.

"I hate when you call me your majesty. You can just call me Adora." She still has her pursed lips, but the look is something softer as her eyelashes flutter and close. "I do like it when you call me princess though."She says absentmindedly as she burrows deeper in the covers. She almost immediately starts snoring leaving Catra both aroused and relieved.

"I'm sorry about last night,"Adora says when she's finally well enough to speak. She spent half the morning retching in a bucket.

"It's fine we all have too much to drink occasionally."She smirks. "Let's call it your initiation into pirate life."

Adora rolls her eyes. "Yes, well seems I'm not suited for it."She still looks a bit pale, even after she managed to hold down breakfast. "I'm sorry I pushed you."She says softly.

Catra sends her a confused look. "You didn't push me you were dead weight for most of the walk."

Adora rolls her eyes. "No Captain. I *pushed* you."She gives her the same dark look from the night before and Catra suddenly realizes what the princess is referring to.

"It's fine, you don't have to mention it."Catra looks out towards the porthole.

She hears Adora mutter something under her breath that sounds suspiciously like *stubborn pirate*. She then reaches out and tilts Catra's chin, making it so she's forced to meet the taller woman's gaze. "If I had won last night, I know what favor I would have called." She leans in closer, and Catra feels dazed, looking up at the princess with not a thought in her head. "I would have asked for a kiss."She says boldly and Catra thinks her heart might have stopped.

"It's a shame then. That you didn't win."She says back her eyes trailing over Adora's lips.

"A damn shame."She agrees. "What are you going to ask for?"She says in that challenging princess voice of hers.

"I haven't decided yet."She could barely breathe let alone *think* with Adora standing so close even as bedraggled and tired as she was.

Adora takes a step back and Catra takes a shuddering breath. "Let me know when you decide."

The storm outside is ranging in a way that is more dangerous than fighting two ships at once. No squabble amongst people could be more dangerous than when the sea itself fights you.

She goes on the captain's quarter to make sure Adora is still below deck, where she's meant to be. She sighs in relief when the princess

is in fact there. "Adora stays inside lock the door and no matter what you dont leave. Alright?" She commands.

Adora takes in Catra's disheveled state with alarm. "Catra but what about you?" She's never heard Adora say her name and it makes her chest tighten.

"I'll be fine. I always am." She all but shoves her in, locking the door behind her.

The crew works tirelessly to steer but there's not much you can do in a storm like this except pray.

Catra is trying to tie up a loose piece of cargo when it happens. A piece of the mast cracks off, and heads directly for Catra, the worst possible situation she could find herself in. She tries to scramble out of the way, but she knows there's no way she can move fast enough. She closes her eyes and hopes death is swift and painless but instead she's knocked out of the way.

She opens her eyes and springs up. "What was that?" She bellows over the thunder. Someone must have run full speed at her to get Catra out of the way.

"The princess went overboard!" Lonnie screams back eyes wide in fear.

"Get me a rope!" She yells and someone ties it securely around her waist. She doesnt hesitate, just pauses long enough to search the water for a blonde head. She sees her below the surface and jumps hoping shell get close enough.

The water is harsh and disorienting, but the burning in her eyes and the cold seeping into her bones cant hope to compare to the sheer panic clawing at her throat.

She tries to keep track of which way is up and down as she swims to where she thinks Adora is and finally she can see the blonde the

moment she gets her she starts swimming up, tugging on the rope, and feels relief when she feels a strong tug back.

The crew haul them up and she lays Adora on the deck. She's not responsive. She's pressing both hands hard on Adora' s chest in a rhythmic fashion, hoping she doesnt have to crack a rib to keep her breathing. Her eyes flutter open and she coughs, sputtering up as water flies out of her mouth. Catra gently pats her back, holding her up as she starts breathing.

"Y oure okay Princess. Its all right."She soothes even though she's dying inside.

She leans on Catra as she takes big gasping breaths and Catra thanks every star for each and every one of them.

She leans down and pulls, carrying Adora into her arms. She closes her eyes and falls limp in Catra's arms but she's breathing and for now, that's what matters. The storm has calmed some so she takes Adora to their room. She strips her down to her underwear, and covers her in a towel, quick to dry her shivering body .

She gets her into warm clothes and under the blankets, hoping that she doesnt catch a fever . Catra strips herself down and does the same, wrapping herself in a blanket and sitting on the floor by the bed, watching Adora.

She opens her eyes an hour later, bloodshot from the water. "Are you alright?"she says groggily . The relief is choking, she'd never been happier to hear someone's voice in her life.

"I'm fine Princess. Are you alright?"She watches as Adora nods, digging her face into the pillow.

"Sleepy ."She of fers.

Catra nods. "That makes sense. Go to sleep and we can talk more when you wake up."

"Stay with me," She says softly .

"Y es princess, Ill stay ."She nods. As if anything could tear her from Adora's side.

"Promise?" She doubles down.

"Promise."

Catra sleeps with one arm on the bed the rest of her body leaning against it as she sat on the ground. Every few hours she wakes up and checks on the princess, who sleeps through the night.

"Good morning Catra."

The relief that Catra felt last night at Adora being alive and well gives way to anger as she looks at the rumpled woman.

"What did you think you were doing Adora? Y ou could have died!" She chastised.

Adora furrows her brow, eyes flashing with anger. "I was thinking that you're an idiot! And *you* could have died!"

"W ell, it's not your place to be worried about whether I died or not Adora. I can take care of myself!" Catra huf fs as she paces the small room.

"What? And it's your place to worry about me? Don't want your precious cargo ruined? W ouldn't want your ransom to go to waste!" She mocks.

Catra turns to face the most stubborn woman she's met in the days of her life. "I don't fucking care about that Adora! Y ou could have *died*." She's surprised when the last word breaks into a sob. "What would I have done if something happened to you?" She whispers her

heartbreak, the thought that's been running through her mind since she pulled Adora out of the tempest.

Adora's face softens slightly but it's still defiant in the way she holds her lips. "I won't apologize for saving your life."

"Then apologize for scaring me half to death."She all but pouts and Adora smiles.

"I'm sorry I worried you, captain. I can't promise I won't do it again."

"Your highness I will lock you in the brig if you do anything like that again."She's joking but it isn't a terrible idea.

Adora rolls her eyes. "Yes yes of course. Now I'm feeling much better, do you think we can take a walk topside?"

"Yes, but I'm not letting you anywhere near the water."They manage to walk around the deck, Catra always between Adora and the water as the crew looked on at the captain and the princess.

Catra is minding her business after a day of toiling on the ship when she feels someone sit on her of all things.

"Adora I swear if you break my hammock I'll end you."She threatens playfully.

"You'll have to sleep in the bed with me then."She says with a raised eyebrow.

"Or down with the rest of the crew."

Adora pouts. "But who would guard me then?"

"As if you need guarding."Catra scoffs. "With how you handle your sword I might have gotten a bodyguard instead of me guarding you." She teases.

She shakes her head. "Seriously . You've been sleeping on this hammock for weeks now, it can't be great for your back. Why don't you sleep next to me tonight?"

"It's only two more days." Catra points out, the words leaving a bitter taste in her mouth.

"Then it shouldn't matter ." She says back. Her eyes look so wide and hopeful. Catra buckles. She isn't sure that she's ever been able to deny Adora anything.

Catra doesn't say anything just lays down on her back. She'd almost forgotten how it feels to lay on an actual mattress. She can't help but relax into it, even though every part of her is aware of her bedmate.

Adora carefully leans towards Catra until she's gingerly placed her head on Catra's shoulder. She waits, Catra can feel her eyes on the side of Catra's face. She turns to look at her and will she ever not be brought to her knees by how beautiful Adora looks?

"Staring is rude Adora." She says it with a raised brow .

She turns red but just nuzzles further into Catra's shoulder, making her face flush. "I'm just getting ready to sleep. Goodnight Catra."

She closes her eyes. Catra takes a moment to drink her in, the softness of her lips, her fluttering eyelashes, the implicit trust of closing her eyes and just laying her head so close to Catra. She raises her hand and gently touches her cheek.

When she wakes up in the morning, they are wrapped so tightly together it takes Catra a full fifteen minutes to disentangle herself without waking Adora up.

The day dwindles precipitously until Eternia is within view, running like water through her hands. Adora would make it home tomorrow as agreed and Catra would never see her smile or hear her laugh or

speak with her ever again. It's completely expected and Catra is coping well.

She avoids the room, staying up on the deck until it's late and all tasks have been done. The crew looks at her with pity as they bid her goodnight, encouraging her to go spend time with Adora.

She opens the door and barely levels a glance in her direction laying on her hammock again.

She can feel Adora's angry stare on her. "Are we just not going to acknowledge this at all?" She finally asks.

"What your majesty?" Catra turns her head to look at the irritated princess.

"Come here." She all but commands.

"You don't tell me what to do." She says stubbornly back. She can't do whatever it is Adora wants. She won't break her own heart in front of her.

She walks to the hammock and grabs Catra's hand, tugging her to sit on the bed with her. She turns fully to look at her. "Catra please." Adora all but whines as she reaches forward, placing her hand on Catra's cheek.

Catra turns her head, making Adora's hand fall away. "Adora, why are you doing this?"

"Why won't you? You obviously want to." She has that stubborn set in her eyes that Catra wants to hate but can't help but love.

"You're my captive. This isn't right." Adora's friendship is invaluable to Catra, but discussing what they have been tiptoeing around is just too much.

"You know I haven't been your captive in a long while."

"Adora tomorrow Im returning you to your kingdom. Youll be a princess and one day the Queen you were born to be. And Ill be a pirate."She never begrudged her station in life but at this moment, she wanted nothing more than to be someone who could court Adora, and sweep her off her feet.

"We have tonight then."Adora insists, gripping one of Catra's hands between her own. Eyes begging. Begging for Catra of all things, as if Adora hasnt slowly but surely conquered every part of her .

"Adora if I give you this last part of me, I fear itll ruin me."She says, trying to focus on anything but how warm, how *right* holding Adora's hand felt.

Adora shakes her head with a soft laugh. "Oh, Captain dont you know?"She brings Catra's hand to her lips placing the gentlest kiss there. "Youve already ruined me for everyone else."

Catra sits stock still, her heart thudding in her ears and her eyes trapped on Adora. She looks so soft under the moonlight coming in from the porthole, so open as if every thought she has is for sharing with Catra.

The thought that she could look at Catra this way? It cracks her chest open, leaving her belly up and exposed, nothing to hide from the blonde.

"Youre sure about this?"She asks tentatively . Shes so afraid of what will happen beyond tomorrow, afraid of how deep shes going to let herself get in this pit of emotion that threatens to swallow her whole.

"I want you."She says simply as if its an uncontroverted fact.

Catra shudders as she reaches forward allowing herself to touch Adora and really feel it for the first time their whole stay. Her skin is so *soft*. Catra didnt know it was possible for skin to feel this way .

Adora closes her eyes, lips slightly parted as she leans into Catra's touch. When she opens her eyes again, they are impossibly dark, the blue of a stormy ocean.

"Please take me." She finally speaks. "That's what pirates do isn't it?" She gives Catra a wry grin. She doesn't say the word pirate with disdain anymore, just a gentle fondness that makes Catra want to weep.

She shakes her head slowly and Adora's face drops into disappointment and hurt. Catra reaches out and pulls her closer, one hand cupping her cheek and the other resting on her hip.

"No Adora, I'm not going to take you. I'm going to worship you." Catra has always been rough, but for Adora, she wants to be soft. She wants to give her things she's never given anyone before, things she doesn't even know for herself.

Adora releases a shuddering breath, eyes searching Catra's. She nods, an almost solemn expression crossing her face. Catra gives herself over to the kiss, Adora's lips supple and soft as she gently guides her down onto the bed.

She pulls the oversized shirt over Adora's head. Leaving her bare before Catra. Her body is ethereal, completely unmarred by any blemish, just gorgeous expanses of soft skin. Catra places her hand on Adora's torso and notices the differences. Her skin is darker. more calloused and scarred. It's served her well, this thick skin, but she can't imagine it will allow her to do what she most needs, making Adora feel good.

She's staring up at Catra with bright eyes looking between her hand and her face. "I want to make you feel good Adora." She means the words to be a promise, not an admission. "Will you show me what you want?"

The question makes a low whine build in the back of her throat. "Catra just just touch me. Please." She's tensing in anticipation,

biting her lip as she looks up at Catra.

She does as commanded, slowly inching both hands up to toy with Adora’s tits. They feel heavy in her hands, the impossibly pink nipples growing tauter as Adora gasps.

"Harder ."She says, and Catra doesnt hesitate, she lays her body on Adora’s as she starts building up the pressure with which she touches her. She bends her head and sucks on one of her nipples. Adora cries out at that.

She reaches one hand lower, sweeping over the warm softness of her belly and reaching between her legs. Adora moans as Catra starts to pump her fingers.

It feels so intimate to hold her close and be inside her all at once. She groans at the sensation, Adora feels so perfect around her fingers, wet and warm. Adora clutches Catra’s curls in one hand, pressing Catra into her cleavage and the other held her back, nails digging into her shoulder blade. The dull pain grounds her, and makes her eye focus on the blonde in her arms.

She doesnt dare even think of the word love, but she can feel it in every touch that she places on Adora’s body, on every touch she receives in return.

"Fuck Adora. Y oure mine. My princess."She cant help the words—underneath it all shes a pirate, covetous and selfish and the biggest treasure shes ever held in her hands is Adora staring at her with wild eyes, body tensing as she closes in on her orgasm.

"Y ours."She agrees breathlessly . "Always yours, Catra." The words taste so good as Adora kisses them on Catras skin even though she knows they are lies. One day, Adora will become a queen and have a consort who will support her through it all, holding her hand and her heart in a way Catra never can.

But Adora is Catra's right now, willingly and honestly. And she'll be damned if she doesn't wring every drop of pleasure from Adora's body so that she can look fondly upon the pirate she might remember from time to time when she's not busy ruling Eternia.

The morning after is a somber one, Catra feels like she's waiting for the gallows as the rowboat that has come to collect Adora reaches the ship.

"This is goodbye. Safe travels princess." Catra grabs Adora's hand and places a chaste kiss on the top of it. As if Adora's body doesn't bear the marks of their ravenous lovemaking.

"Goodbye captain." She says faintly, eyes welling with tears.

Catra digs her toes into her boots to keep from chasing her. From asking her to run away with her forever, to just kiss the freckles on her back and lay on her chest and never look back. She wants all those things so badly, but Adora has an important future. She has a duty to her people and Catra can't stand in the way of that. And she could never leave the sea.

She turns one last time and gives Catra a desperate look as if Catra would have some magical fix that would lead to them being together. She doesn't. She refuses to sail away until the Eternian ship is docked and Adora is only a memory that lives in her skin.

The crew leaves her well enough alone until the sun is setting. "Where to next captain?" Lonnie asks softly as Catra keeps staring at that damn dock.

"Find a port of call for the crew to rest and take their portion of the ransom. I need to think."

She marches towards the captain's quarters not bothering to see where or when Lonnie picks to set sail.

She locks the door after she closes it and lays back in her bed. After sleeping in the hammock for the better part of six weeks it feels huge. She turns and sure enough, the whole bed smells of Adora. She breathes deep and for a moment she pretends that Adora is just up on the deck and that Catra is good enough to keep her there.

She thought that time without Adora would get easier not harder, but every day proved her wrong. She walks through each day in a haze, finding her mind wandering

She has to stop in Eternia of all places to pick up cargo, some of the legitimate business dealings she has to obfuscate her less savory ventures. Every step in the Eternian capital leaves her feeling a little less hollow. She knows she won't run into Adora there, but she can't help but wonder if she'd recently visited the docks, she looks out over the water and thinks of Catra at all.

She makes it all the way to the marketplace when she's surprised by five guard chasing after her. She runs, not knowing why they're following her, but realizing she'll likely be dead if they catch her .

They bring her into the castle and Catra's heart thuds unevenly in her chest. She's afraid of what her punishment might be, but another part of her is desperate to see Adora one last time before she ends up hanged. Instead of a jail cell, she's taken to the throne room, which she finds odd.

It must look comical, three burly guards manhandling her when she's smaller than any of them. It's not like she can go anywhere, she is bound and surrounded.

"There's no need for the chains." Adora has King Randor's blue eyes and smile but that's where the similarities end. He is sitting on his throne, the queen by his side. Her eyes dart between the two, trying to figure out what is happening.

The guards remove the chains and she’s now standing of her own volition in front of Adora’s parents.

"Do you know why you're here?" King Randor asks, hands resting leisurely on the armrests of his throne.

"Piracy seems like a good wager ." She ventures with a smile.

King Randor tosses a look over at Queen Marlena. "She's funny ." He says gruffly and Catra can't tell if he means it as a compliment or not.

"Adora said she would be." The Queen says. She's a regal wisp of a woman with fiery red hair and kind green eyes. Catra’s eyes snap between the two her heart clenching at the mention of the princess.

He grunts, eyeing Catra again. "What do you think would make someone a good suitor for Adora?" He directs the question at her , and her stomach drops at the thought of Adora finding someone else.

"I'm not worthy to talk of such matters." She says tightly . Is this a new punishment for piracy? Dangling the happy future she can never hope to obtain a breath away?

"No one really is as far as I'm concerned." His dark brow furrows. "But I don't want a worthy match for Adora. I want her to be happy . A happy match." He says the last sentence under his breath.

"Match?" She echoes the word in confusion.

The King looks up towards the heavens. "She'd explain it better if she just"—

"I'm so sorry I'm late." Adora walks in and it's like the sun appears on the horizon. When she sees Catra she absolutely beams making a beeline for her.

She screeches to a halt two feet away from Catra, close enough that Catra could touch her if she just reached. She forgot exactly how

radiant Adora is. No memory could do her justice. Instead of the pants and loose-fitted shirts she wore on the ship, she was wearing a gorgeous white dress, and on her head, a tiara.

She looks like every bit of a princess in a way that's different from how she was when she was with Catra. On the ship, it was easy to forget that she wasn't just Adora but surrounded by all of her guards, her riches, and her regents, it was impossible to ignore.

"Adora?" She asks breathlessly . She notes that the princess doesn't seem surprised to see her there. "Did you have me arrested?"

She winces at that. "A little." She looks so apologetic that Catra isn't even sure she could find anger in herself even if she does end with a noose around her neck. "I have an explanation."

"Okay then, princess." She nods. She can feel the Eternian regents' eyes on her but she can't bear to look away from Adora. She'd missed her so fiercely in the last six months that she's not sure there's anything that could make her stop staring.

"You're very hard to find." She says nervously . "So I deployed the resources I had."

"So, what I'm to understand is that you wished to kidnap me?" She can't help the tease that flies out of her mouth.

Adora's eyes go impossibly soft as she takes a step closer. Then in front of a room full of people, she leans down and places a chaste kiss on Catra's lips.

"Yes." She says with that naked honesty that makes Catra's bones melt.

"Okay , I've seen enough." This time the Queen speaks out.

Adora looks up at her with a tense look which makes Catra realize this must have been some type of test.

"You may have what you wish Adora. But under our terms." The Queen says sternly.

For a moment a displeased pout forms on Adora's lips but she seems to abandon the endeavor in favor of pulling Catra into her arms. "What's happening exactly?" She whispers into the blonde shoulder, holding her back just as tightly.

"My parents agreed to grant you a pardon if you wish it," A nervous look crosses her face.

Catra stares back at Adora as naked shock runs through her. "Adora why would they possibly want to do that?" Catra kidnapped their daughter. She had blood on her hands. she was a pirate through and through, there was no reason for them to forgive her for *any* of it.

"I told them about slave ships, and I've been working on getting some joint support to stop their passage through various kingdoms. Given that most of your crimes relate to liberating slaves my parents are willing to turn a blind eye."

It seems Adora drew a very generous depiction of Catra's piracy, but she isn't about to argue that she should be punished.

"But not without recompense." The King interrupts, directing his words and his gaze at Catra.

She swallows nervously as she looks at the regent. The man was absolutely huge, a true bear. She hadn't realized *how* tall until he stands and walks toward Catra, towering over her.

"Our Adora says that you love her, is that true?" He demands.

Catra's eyes fly to Adora's face where she's blushing red looking down at the ground. She almost wishes to tease the princess for being so bold in her assumptions, but she can't do anything but say the truth.

I do. I love her very much."

It's been obvious to Catra that her feelings ran bone deep these last few months as she stared at the ocean and longed for a different shade of blue. She hasn't been able to read her favorite book since Adora left. The worst of it was how sometimes she slept in her hammock so she could pretend that Adora was in the next bed over, sleeping softly.

Adora's shoulders dropped down with relief as if she was afraid of what Catra might say to that. the king stares at her for a moment longer.

"Then if you love her and you wish to be together , you need to accept a naval commission and a new identity and you must leave your life of piracy behind."He says resolutely , eyes kind but firm.

Catra looks at Adora again unable to keep her gaze away from the blonde for long. There's so much in that sentence that doesn't make sense but there's only one thing that really matters. "Be together"? She whispers, the words breathing life into her.

Adora's smile is soft. "T ogether."She af firms.

Catra hears a choked sound, and she realizes it's coming from her . She blinks her eyes and looks back at King Randor

"What of my crew"?She asks. She couldn't leave them to hang, she doesn't have it in her .

He shakes his head. "The pardon is for you alone and even that is a significant concession. However, we won't actively look for them as long as they leave Eternian ships be."She looks between the women briefly. "I know this is a momentous decision. Y ou have until tomorrow to decide. If you don't accept, then for my daughter 's sake we will allow you to leave Eternia. But you can never step foot on Eternian soil again and you must leave our ships be."

Catra hasn't gone after an Eternian ship since she kidnapped Adora. "Can I have some time alone with the princess?"

A look of irritation passes over the king's face but the queen smiles knowingly. "This is what we wanted for her Randor ." the Queen calls gently from her throne.

He sighs and rolls his eyes. "I know Marlena, but *her honor*."The queen rolls her eyes but says nothing. Catra suspects that Queen Marlena might know a little more about the state of Adora's honor than the King.

"I'll show you to your room."Adora cuts in quickly because there can be more debate about the propriety of such things. Adora grabs her hand and leads her away. They walk through a dizzying amount of hallways, tasteful art, and cold stone walls greeting them at every turn. Finally, Adora stops at a large door swinging it open and pulling Catra inside.

They stare at each other nervously. Catra can't even begin to ask everything she needs to ask because all she wants to do is stare at Adora and marvel that she loves her. That she wants Catra.

She lets out a sigh followed by a smile. "What did you do princess?" And it sounds like when she's checking on Adora's bungled sailor knots.

Adora is bashful looking away for a moment. That doesn't sit right with Catra. She reaches out and grabs her hand pulling one of them up to her face so that she could kiss her palm, her palm, just littering kisses everywhere she can touch.

That seems to give Adora the courage she needs to look up at Catra. "I've been wearing my parents down,"she explains, "I know that we never spoke of a path forward or love, but even if you rejected me now—I had to know that I tried."She looks nervously at Catra as if she expects her to do just that.

"Adora I don't know what to say ."She says haltingly . "Of course, I want to be with you, but I'm not fit to be anyone's wife. Least of all the Queen's consort."

"Slow down pirate, no one's talking about marriage."She says with an amused smirk. Catra blushes as she realized what she implied.

"You know what I mean."She gives Adora a testy look. She sobers slightly, gripping Catras hand which is still raised to her face.

"You have a lot to think about Catra. I'm asking you to give up a lot for me, and we haven't really known each other very long."She puts her hand on Catra's cheek. "But I feel as if my heart knows you. And I want to do right by you, whatever that entails."Adora pins Catra with her stare. "So, think about what you want for yourself. Don't worry about being good enough because you don't get to decide that. I decide what I deserve, and I want you Catra."

"So, you want me, princess?"She says with a soft smile.

"I love you."She leans her forehead again Catra's. "I've known no peace since I left you."

"I love you too Adora."She closes her eyes and breathes her in. "I've thought of nothing but you every day. Lonnie has been yelling at me for mooning about."

Adora lets out a soft laugh. "Mooning after me, pirate?"

Catra nods her head still staying close to Adora. She wraps her arms around Catra and for once the pirate feels small. "I want to be with you, Adora."She longs for Adora, she has since she met her but—"It can't be like this."

Adora freezes, taking a step back and looking down at the pirate with uncomprehending eyes. "What do you mean?"

"Adora, you said you understand what you're asking me to give up but I don't think you do." She says slowly. "Do you remember when we sat on the deck together and we talked about Eternia?"

"Of course, Catra."

"You find this life stifling, but you bear your duty so well because you have an unending well of love for your people. It's one of the things I love about you." She says softly. "But me? I don't love Eternia, I've hardly been here. And if you, a woman who was groomed for this life finds it stifling then"—

"Then you'd hate it," Adora whispers as understanding dawns on her. "You'd hate your life here and then you'd resent me for making you give everything up for this. So I could have what I want."

Catra holds her tight to her chest. "It's a wonderful thought love. But I'm not suited for this life and I wouldn't like who I'd have to become to be by your side in this way." Even just walking through the palace, imagining herself day to day made her feel like she would crawl out of her own skin. She can't be who Adora needs, not with this, even if it breaks her heart that it's true.

"I don't want to change you Catra. I just—I missed you and I wanted you *here* so much that I didn't think about much more than that I hoped you loved me enough to give up everything for me. It was selfish."

"It was very pirate of you," Catra says with a raised brow. Adora shoves her but then brings her close again, resting her head on the shorter woman's chin.

"So, what do we do?" Adora whispers while dropping a kiss on her head. She looks up at the blonde, thinking.

"Neither of us can give up our lives for the other, but maybe there's something else." Catra lets a smirk cross her face. "Besides

princess, your parents gave me until tomorrow. We have all night to figure it out."

Adora raised an eyebrow, "and what would we do all night pirate?"

Her eyes soften. "I've missed you. Tell me how you've been?"

"Of course."Adora leads her to the bed, and they stay wrapped in each other's arms all night, whispering their love across the other's skin and planning for a tomorrow that can sustain them both.

A Year Later

Adora runs a lazy hand along the side of Catra's ribs, over a scar she received during her time at the naval academy. Her body is littered with scars from all kinds of misadventures with the wrong end of a weapon. She tenses a bit as she notices how intently Adora stares at the scar.

Adora shakes her head, and slowly lowers her lips to kiss the scar. Adora has kissed every inch of her body dozens of times at this point but the way she reverently stares as she presses her lips to the scar makes Catra shiver.

"Your scars are beautiful Catra, just like every part of you."She gently reminds, her lips still brushing against Catra's torso. Adora always took to finding the ugliest parts of Catra and making them seem easy to love.

"I love you,"Catra tells her. She'd been showing her for the last two days with her hands and her lips, but it bears mentioning at every opportunity they have together. "How much longer do we have?"

She's hoping to have Adora read to her again before their time is out. What was once a symbol of exactly how unloved Catra was is now one of her favorite things to do with her love.

Adora's eyes cloud over as she presses another kiss to Catra's arm. "Not much longer I'm afraid."

Catra groans closing her eyes. "How are your parents anyway?"

"God, not exactly thrilled that the heir to the throne is disappearing every few months to go gallivanting with a pirate, but they cope." She teases, although there is an underpinning of sadness that Catra feels resonates in her chest.

"They don't *know* that you're gallivanting with a pirate." Catra protests. They have tried their best to leave their meetings discrete if only so Adora could save face when she returns home.

Adora scoffs. "They aren't stupid Catra."

"They must hate me." She surmises. She can't imagine what King Randor thinks of her now, sullying Adora's honor at every turn as far as he was concerned.

"No! They don't understand the choices we've made but they know those choices have been as much mine as yours." She assures as she presses her forehead against Catra's.

Catra holds Adora close running her hands up and down her side, trying to memorize the way that her naked body feels pressed up to her. It's all she would have until she could see her again.

Adora sighs, looking at Catra with mournful eyes. "I have to go."

Catra pouts, although she knows it won't solve more. "Five more minutes?"

She gives her a dubious look. "That's what you said before the last round."

"And I didn't hear you complaining when I was between your thighs." She goads, enjoying the way Adora looks, blushing in Catra's bed.

When she can still taste Adora on her lips, she cant find it in herself to regret the delay tactic.

"Help me lace up?" She asks softly with a deep sadness in her eyes that Catra wishes she could make disappear.

"Anything you want princess."

They step out of the bed and Adora dresses most of the way but she needs help with the corset. Catra starts to slowly tug on the laces, running her fingers between the gaps right before they close up. She looks at the expanses of Adora's skin, enjoying looking at the love bites and scratches that disappear as her outfit comes together. She finally finishes, placing a soft kiss on her neck before she steps back.

Adora looks every bit the regent she is, only her hair hinting and how she'd spent the last few days locked away in the captain's quarters with Catra, a slice of heaven on the harborside of Salineas.

Adora makes to step toward the door, but Catra grips her hands for a moment. "Do you remember the dice game we played when you were first on the ship?"

Adora instantly smiles at the memory. "You mean when I tried to seduce you and you refused my advances because you are a brooding pirate with a consent kink?"

Catra shakes her head. "You're insufferable." She laughs, "I'm calling in my favor from that night."

Adora's eyes light up with curiosity. "And what does my love wish from me?"

Catra tries to keep from melting at Adora's words and her touch but it's a close thing. "I want two weeks with you. Somewhere we can be together in public. Hold hands, maybe kiss on the beach."

Adora bites her lip. "That's a lot of time Catra."

I know . It doesnt have to be right away but I thought it could be something to look forward to."She explains.

Adora pulls her into a fierce hug. "That sounds really nice."She admits. I love you Catra. There' s nothing I wouldnt do to be with you."

Except there was. She wouldnt leave her crown and Catra wouldnt leave the sea. Catra lets the half-truth go. It was true in all the ways that truly mattered to them.

"Then start planning princess. Y ou just need to tell me when you can skip out and Ill arrange everything else."Adora deserves more romance, She pulls the blonde in for a final kiss. "Ill be thinking of you from the moment we part to the moment you're back in my arms."Catra breathes out.

Adora nods tightly. "It' s only three months. Ill see you soon dearest." She touches Catra's cheek then turns away and quickly walks out the door. They've found that a quick goodbye in Catra' s bedroom is the least painful goodbye for them both.

Catra stands still in the room, the first few minutes after Adora leaves are always the hardest. It's hard to breathe when she's spent so much time with Adora and then ends up with only the ghost of her on the bedsheets.

They only get a handful of visits a year and as many love letters as Seahawk is willing to ferry to and from Eternia. It's so little and yet it's so much when compared to not having Adora at all.

It doesnt matter , the time or the distance between them. Catra would always find a way to return home. To Adora.

End Notes

Legitimately I was like "I want to write all the pirate tropes" but to actually do that I would have needed like 100k words there are simply TOO MANY so this is what is happening instead. Seriously, I was like easy 7k fic with a few tropes, and boom, then it got past 10k and I realized I had to let some tropes go lol.

I struggled a lot with the ending. It was difficult to grapple with the Adora and Catra I wrote, it didn't feel like either would budge and just give up everything but I also didn't want a very sad ending. I thought this would be a good compromise. I plotted out three different endings to figure this out though lol. Let me know your thoughts. Also, shout out to yagirlStatic for giving my input and hearing my endless fretting about the ending.

Please kudos and comment if the spirit moves you it makes me a happy clam, And follow me on Twitter if you'd like some sneak peeks and other content!

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!